

Unreasonable Hospitality

The Remarkable Power of Giving People More Than They Expect

A Companion Guide

Book (nonfiction) by Will Guidara - Optimism Press, 2022

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Coverage: full content. This is nonfiction, so there are no plot twists to spoil; the guide discusses the book's stories and ideas freely.

Quick Take

Yes, read it. Will Guidara took a struggling two-star brasserie called Eleven Madison Park and, eleven years later, turned it into the number one restaurant in the world. This book is how he did it, but it is not really a restaurant book. It is a leadership and customer-experience book wearing a chef's coat. The whole philosophy radiates out from one cheap, improvised gesture: a two-dollar street-cart hot dog, plated like haute cuisine, that meant more to a table of guests than any caviar course he ever served. From that one moment Guidara builds a simple, durable argument: no matter what business you are in, you can choose to be in the hospitality business. Critics and readers agree. It is a New York Times bestseller, has sold over a million copies, and sits at roughly 4.41 out of 5 on Goodreads across more than 40,000 ratings, which is unusually high for a business book. The one fair knock: it reads more like a great restaurant memoir than a tidy step-by-step manual. If you want stories that reframe how you think about taking care of people, this delivers. If you want a checklist, you will have to build it yourself, which is partly the point.

About the Author

Will Guidara was practically raised in dining rooms. His father, Frank Guidara, was a heavyweight restaurant executive who ran Restaurant Associates, the Wolfgang Puck Food Company, Au Bon Pain, and Pizzeria UNO, so hospitality was the family trade. Will graduated from Cornell's hospitality school and took over Eleven Madison Park (EMP) at just 26, when it was a well-regarded but unremarkable two-star brasserie. Partnered with chef Daniel Humm, he spent the next decade pushing it relentlessly upmarket. The payoff: four stars from the New York Times, three Michelin stars, and the top spot on the World's 50 Best Restaurants list in 2017.

The partnership did not last forever. In July 2019, Guidara and Humm dissolved their Make It Nice company (EMP, The NoMad, Made Nice), with Humm buying out Guidara's shares; they described it as a marriage that had run its course. That ending is part of what gave Guidara the distance to write this book. Today he runs the Welcome Conference, an annual hospitality gathering, and founded a company called Thank You that consults leaders across industries. He is also a paid keynote speaker and, notably, a credited co-producer on the FX series *The Bear*. (Quick fact-check note for the record: a few current web write-ups misdate the Humm split as 2026. It was 2019.)

What the Critics Say

The reception has been warm and broad. Beyond the bestseller status and million-plus copies sold, the book found a second life as a corporate leadership staple, assigned and quoted in tech, healthcare, retail, financial services, higher-ed fundraising, and beyond. The Simon Sinek connection helped: the book came out under Sinek's Optimism Press imprint, and Sinek hosted

Guidara on his podcast the week of launch, which planted it firmly in the business-leadership aisle rather than the food-memoir shelf.

Guidara's 2022 TED talk, "The secret ingredients of great hospitality," built around the hot dog story, became the on-ramp for a lot of readers and is still the cleanest 15-minute summary of the whole idea.

The most common criticism is gentle: some readers wanted a more generalizable how-to framework and instead got a restaurant autobiography. That is true, but it is also why the stories stick. The single most quoted line in the book is its thesis in miniature:

*"'Black and white' means you're doing your job with competence and efficiency;
'color' means you make people feel great about the job you're doing."*

Will Guidara, Unreasonable Hospitality

Themes and What Makes It Work

Service is black and white. Hospitality is color.

This is the conceptual heart of the book. Service is technical and one-directional: the right plate, to the right person, at the right time. It is a monologue. Hospitality is emotional and two-directional: it is about how the interaction makes the person feel. It is a dialogue. Guidara's favorite answer to give in job interviews, and his favorite to receive, was exactly that line: service is black and white, hospitality is color. Most organizations are competent at service and mediocre at hospitality, and the gap is where the opportunity lives.

The 95/5 rule.

Guidara's antidote to the worry that "unreasonable" generosity is just reckless spending: manage 95 percent of your business down to the penny, then spend the last 5 percent foolishly. That last sliver, the small and unexpected gestures, carries an outsize emotional punch. Framed this way, extravagant generosity becomes a disciplined line item rather than a budget leak. For non-restaurant readers this is the most portable, actionable idea in the book.

Be present, slow down, listen.

Most of Guidara's signature moments started with someone on his team actually hearing what a guest said: the tourists who never got a New York hot dog, the couple celebrating an anniversary, the kid who wanted to build a sandcastle. The gestures are memorable, but the underlying skill is attention. You cannot give people more than they expect if you are not paying enough attention to know what they want.

Hire for it, then get out of the way.

Guidara says he hired people who were "curious about what they didn't know and generous with what they did." Then he gave them real autonomy to invent their own guest moments,

even creating a role (the "Dreamweaver") whose whole job was to engineer surprises. The leadership spine of the book is familiar but well told: take care of your people first so they can take care of guests, praise in public, criticize in private, and protect a clear set of values when you hire.

What You Might Not Know

- **The hot dog.** The whole book traces back to a roughly two-dollar hot dog. During a 2010 lunch, Guidara overheard departing European tourists lament that they had eaten at the city's finest restaurants but never had a classic New York street dog. He ran out, bought one from a cart, had Daniel Humm plate it (cut in four, a swipe of mustard, artisanal sauerkraut), and served it as a surprise course. He later said he had served tens of millions of dollars of wagyu and caviar and never seen a reaction like the one that hot dog got.
- **The Sinek launch.** The book launched under Simon Sinek's Optimism Press, and Sinek featured Guidara as the season-five opener of his podcast "A Bit of Optimism" the week before release. That pairing is a big reason it broke out beyond the food world.
- **The Bear connection.** Guidara is a credited co-producer on *The Bear* and earned a story credit on an episode. The book itself appears on screen in the Season 2 episode "Forks," where Richie reads it during his fine-dining conversion. That cameo gave the book a whole second wave of readers.
- **A field guide exists.** There is now an official companion workbook, "Unreasonable Hospitality: The Field Guide" (2024), full of exercises to help teams actually apply the principles. If your knock on the book is that it is light on how-to, the Field Guide is the answer.
- **A side gig.** Guidara also briefly hosted an unrelated cooking-competition show, "The Big Brunch" (HBO Max, 2022), with Dan Levy and Sohla El-Waylly.

On Screen and In Your Ears

There is no direct film or TV adaptation of the book, but there is plenty of companion viewing and listening:

- **Guidara's TED talk.** The 15-minute thesis. The best quick companion to the book, built around the hot dog story, and the easiest thing to send a team that will not all finish the book.
- **"7 Days Out."** An episode of this Netflix series follows Humm and Guidara through the high-stakes reopening of Eleven Madison Park around its 2017 world-number-one era. This is the best real footage of the actual operation the book describes.
- **"The Bear."** Not an adaptation, but the closest dramatization of this hospitality ethos, with Guidara directly involved behind the camera. The "Forks" episode is the most on-the-nose

expression of the book's philosophy on screen. (Note: chef Daniel Humm has appeared as a guest on "Chef's Table," but there is no dedicated EMP episode.)

- **The audiobook.** Read by Guidara himself, about 8 hours 38 minutes. Worth choosing in audio. This is a memoir that lives on the author's delivery of his signature stories, and his narration lands the emotional beats better than print.
- **Podcasts.** For audio-first teams, his conversations on Simon Sinek's "A Bit of Optimism" and "The Dave Chang Show" (Hospitality First) are the most substantive long-form expansions of the book.

If You Liked This

- **Setting the Table - Danny Meyer (2006).** The essential pairing. Meyer was Guidara's first boss and mentor, and this book on "enlightened hospitality" is the direct predecessor. Read them back to back to trace the whole lineage of hospitality-as-business-philosophy.
- **The Power of Moments - Chip & Dan Heath (2017).** The research-backed "why" behind Guidara's instinct. Explains why brief peak experiences define how people remember everything else. Its Magic Castle Hotel "Popsicle Hotline" is a cousin of the hot dog move.
- **Leaders Eat Last - Simon Sinek (2014).** The internal-team half of the equation. Where Guidara focuses on the guest, Sinek focuses on the culture and "circle of safety" that lets a team deliver. The two are connected; Sinek hosted Guidara on his podcast.
- **The Ride of a Lifetime - Bob Iger (2019).** Hospitality and experience-obsession at enterprise scale. Good for the leader asking how this kind of culture survives at ten thousand employees instead of one dining room.
- **Kitchen Confidential - Anthony Bourdain (2000).** The grittier counterpoint for restaurant-curious readers. Bourdain's back-of-house chaos is the raw underside of the polished front-of-house world Guidara perfected.

Questions for a Leadership Team or Book Club

1. Guidara's hot dog cost almost nothing but created a signature memory. What is the cheapest "unreasonable" gesture our team could give a customer or colleague this month?
2. He distinguishes service (the food arrives correct) from hospitality (how it makes you feel). Where are we excellent at service but only mediocre at hospitality?
3. He argues any organization can choose to be in the hospitality business. Do we agree, and how would it change what we measure if we did?
4. Unreasonable hospitality means letting people make gestures with no guaranteed payback. What guardrails would let our team take those swings without it turning into chaos? (Think 95/5.)
5. Map our customer's, or our new hire's, journey. Where is the current peak moment, and where is the pit we should fix first?

6. Guidara's culture depended on hiring for and protecting specific values. What are the two or three non-negotiable values our hospitality would be built on, and are we actually hiring for them?

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